

The Freelancer Money Admin Quick-Start

The 2026 tax deadlines you can't miss, the one invoice habit that gets you paid faster, and a 60-second self-audit.

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2026 Quarterly Tax Deadlines

If you expect to owe \$1,000+ in federal tax for the year after withholding/credits, the IRS expects estimated tax paid quarterly, not once at filing time. Miss one and you can owe a penalty even if you pay in full by April.

Quarter	Due Date	Covers
Q1	April 15, 2026	income from Jan 1 - Mar 31
Q2	June 15, 2026	income from Apr 1 - May 31
Q3	September 15, 2026	income from Jun 1 - Aug 31
Q4	January 15, 2027	income from Sep 1 - Dec 31

How much to set aside: Set aside 25-30% of net profit for taxes, the moment you get paid — not at quarter-end when it may already be spent.

The Invoice Habit That Gets You Paid Faster

- Put a specific due date on every invoice. "Due on receipt" is a due date, but a calendar date removes all ambiguity about when a client is officially late.
- State your payment terms (Net 15, Net 30, etc.) on the invoice itself, not just in the original contract — clients reference the invoice, not a three-month-old email thread.
- Take a deposit (typically 25-50%) on any project over roughly a week of work. It's the single biggest lever for reducing non-payment risk, and it filters out clients who were never going to pay anyway.
- Disclose your late fee before work starts (in the proposal/contract), then restate it on the invoice. A late fee sprung on someone after the fact is much harder to actually collect.

Your 60-Second Money Admin Self-Audit

- [] Do you know your exact self-employment tax rate (not a guess)?
- [] Have you set aside money for Q3 2026 taxes (due September 15) yet?
- [] Does every invoice you send have a specific due date on it?
- [] Do you take a deposit on projects over a week of work?
- [] Do you have a ready-to-send reminder email for a late invoice, or do you write one from scratch each time?

If you answered "no" to two or more of these, that's normal — most freelancers handle money admin reactively because nobody teaches it. The two full toolkits this checklist is drawn from go much deeper: exact self-employment tax calculations from your own numbers, all 17 real IRS Schedule C expense categories, a 4-stage ready-to-copy reminder email sequence, and spreadsheets that do the tracking for you automatically.

The Freelancer Quarterly Tax & Expense Tracker (2026 Edition) — \$19 • The Freelancer Invoice & Late-Payment Toolkit — \$19 • both together as The Freelancer Money Bundle — \$29.